



Jade

△ Polished jadeite stone in its most typical colour

There are two distinct minerals both called jade – nephrite and jadeite. They have very different textures: jadeite is made of interlocking, blocky, granular crystals whereas nephrite is fibrous. Nephrite comes only in cream and shades of green, while jadeite comes in many other colours, with white as its pure form. The most valuable is emerald green, which is coloured by chromium and known as Imperial Jade. The name jade comes from the Spanish *piedra de hijada*, “loin stone”, named in the belief that it cured kidney ailments.

Specification (jadeite)

Chemical name Sodium, iron, aluminium silicate
Formula $\text{Na}(\text{Al},\text{Fe})\text{Si}_2\text{O}_6$ | **Colours** White, green, lavender, pink, brown, orange, yellow, red, blue, or black | **Structure** Monoclinic
Hardness 6–7 | **SG** 3.2–3.4 | **RI** 1.66–1.68 | **Lustre** Vitreous to greasy | **Streak** White | **Locations** Myanmar, Japan

Rough



Sawn block | This jadeite block is translucent with good internal colour patterning and a typical sugary, granular texture. Typically, a block in this condition would be in a fit state for a lapidary to carve into decorative shapes or cut up into cabochons.

Veins of lighter material



Slice of veined jadeite | The white streaks in this dark jadeite create an interesting contrast. The green colouring comes from the presence of iron.

Cut



Jadeite oval cabochon | The elongated cut and smooth dome of this oval cabochon emphasizes its translucency and blue-green colour cast.

Olmec jade

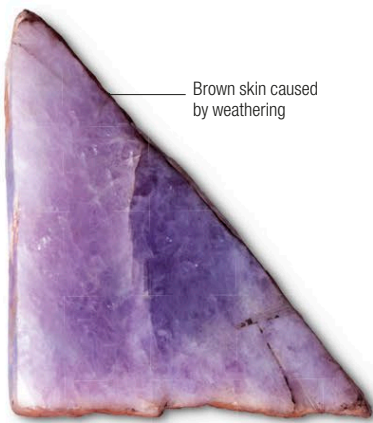
Jadeite or nephrite

The Olmecs were the first of the Mesoamericans (people of Mexico, and Central and South America) to discover and carve jadeite, but, until the late 16th century, virtually all European jade was nephrite. The Spanish discovered that the Aztecs of Mexico prized a green stone thought to be the same. In 1863, a jade carving was analysed and found to be different. It was named jadeite. For Mesoamericans, jadeite had a similar cultural value to nephrite in China, and was more highly prized than gold.



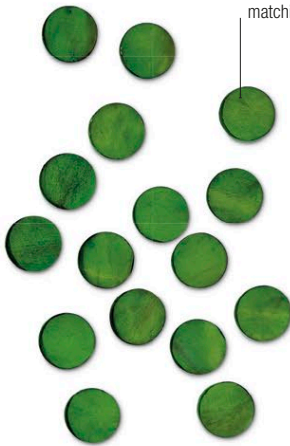
Votive axehead This Olmec jadeite axehead was carved between 1200 and 400 BCE.

Brown skin caused by weathering



Polished jadeite slice | The lavender of this example (caused by manganese) is among the most prized of jadeite colours. The brown skin can be incorporated into carvings.

Close colour matching



Nephrite cabochons | The round cabochons in this group are well matched for size and colour, so that they can be mounted together in a jewellery setting.